PAWAR IN THE DOCK

A DISPUTED LAND DEAL INVOLVING AJIT PAWAR'S SON PARTH PUTS THE NCP CHIEF AND DEPUTY CM ON THE DEFENSIVE AND EXPOSES CRACKS IN THE RULING MAHAYUTI AHEAD OF LOCAL BODY POLLS

By DHAVAL S. KULKARNI



Maharashtra deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar's political career has rarely been without controversy—be it graft allegations in irrigation contracts, charges of irregularities in the Maharashtra State Cooperative Bank, coalition flip-flops, or splitting the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP). The latest challenge comes from a multi-crore disputed land deal in Pune linked to his son Parth.

The scandal involving the state's ministers and leaders comes amid the intensifying tussle for political space and power within the ruling Mahayuti, comprising Ajit's NCP, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Shiv Sena, ahead of the local bodies election slated for next month.

In May, Amadea Enterprises LLP—in which Parth, Ajit's elder son, and his maternal cousin Digvijay Amarsinh Patil are directors—purchased around 40 acres of prime land in Pune's Mundhwa-Koregaon Park. Amadea entered a Rs 300 crore sale deed, when the market value of the land may be around Rs 1,800 crore. Just Rs 500 was paid as stamp duty instead of Rs 21 crore, leading to a loss of revenue for the exchequer. The government land is on lease with the Botanical Survey of India till 2038 (see *A Shady Land Deal*).

After the controversy broke early this month, an FIR was filed against three persons, including Patil, but what has raised eyebrows is that Parth was not named, despite holding a majority stake in the company. Tehsildar Suryakant Yewale and sub-registrar R.B. Taru (named in the FIR) have been suspended. Also booked was Sheetal Tejwani, who holds the powers of attorney from the 272 descendants of the original landowners from the Mahar (Buddhist Dalit) community. The Mahars had been given this land by the British as *watan* or grants in return for their hereditary services to the village community.

Ajit, for his part, had earlier announced that the sale deed had been cancelled and that "not even a rupee was invested" in the transaction. Denying any link to the deal, he did admit that he was aware that this transaction was in the offing. "Around three to four months ago, I came to know that something was underway," he told reporters. "I said I would not tolerate such wrongdoings... and gave clear instructions to this effect." Chief minister Devendra Fadnavis admitted that "prima facie, the facts coming forth were serious" and said the signatories to the deal and the vendors had been named in the FIR. "There is no reason for us to shield anyone," he added. However, on November 18, a committee headed by a joint inspector general of registration, indicted only the three persons named in the FIR. That said, a parallel probe is underway by a panel led by additional chief secretary (revenue) Vikas Kharge.

Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) leader and former leader of the Opposition Ambadas Danve has